



DAVID SHAW
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Taian Table has always been the vision of Chef and Founder Stefan Stiller. Founded in April 2016, Taian Table is the culmination of Stefan's vision for a small, intimate, and highly food-driven dining destination, centered around an open kitchen and a tasting menu crafted from the best seasonal produce. Through Taian Table, Stefan hopes to bring together like-minded people, and break the boundaries of traditional fine dining. Every six weeks, the team creates an entirely new tasting menu, using the best ingredients available in Shanghai. The style of cooking is refined, modern, and predominantly European, but many dishes bear a distinctive Asian touch. The dining experience at Taian Table is centered on its open kitchen, around which guests are seated much like spectators at an arena. Each dish is prepared in front of guests, and introduced personally by chefs and staff, creating an interactive and intimate dining experience. Just five months after opening, Taian Table received a Michelin star in September 2016 in the inaugural edition of the Michelin Guide Shanghai. In September 2019, Taian Table received two Michelin stars in the 2020 Guide.



TAIAN TABLE MENU NO.28

WELCOME SNACKS & NIBBLES

MARINATED BABY HEIRLOOM TOMATOES

Burrata | Basil

ARTICHOKE

Foie Gras Terrine | Vinaigrette

SEA URCHIN

Sour-Dough Bread | Brown Butter

BRITTANY BLUE LOBSTER

Chanterelles Mushrooms | Fresh Almonds

SEARED HOKKAIDO SCALLOP

Bone Marrow | Glazed Leeks

DOVER SOLE

Porcini Mushrooms | Beluga Lentils

RHEINISCHER SAUERBRATEN

“Slow braised Beef Cheek”

Chanterelle Mushrooms | Cauliflower

WATERMELON SORBET

Pickled Watermelon Skin | Mint

PIGEON BREAST

Roasted Pigeon Dashi | Okinawa Spinach | Baby Potato

“UMEBOSHI” CREAM CHEESE

Matcha | Dried Strawberries

BLACK CURRANT

Tonka Bean | Black Berries

FAREWELL SWEETS



WELCOME SNACKS

Crackers and Macadamia

My degustation experience at Taian Table opens up with a trio of snacks exhibiting seaweed crackers, pizza crackers with prosciutto, and housemade macadamia. Albeit to their rich and enjoyable flavors, all of the three snacks are dry and fails to seduce me. The seaweed cracker has a lighter and more airy texture while the pizza cracker is perhaps too hard to enjoy. A glass of Duval Leroy champagne is offered as the first glass of the premier wine pairing program I ordered, unfortunately, the champagne carries neither euphoric texture nor hypnotic aroma.



CHAMPAGNE DUVAL LEROY

Fleur de Champagne Premier Cru

Amuse bouches are soon being presented at a much higher level than the beginning snacks. A mousse of mushroom on top of a tart of pickled ginger immediately drenched me in an explosive bouquet of earthy aroma, while a bite of carpaccio of Chinese mustard, squid ink cracker, and yogurt soon counters the richness, and a foie gras bourbon nesting inside a sphere of hazelnut chocolate brings equilibrium to the trio by recapitulating the richness and creaminess I experienced from the first amuse and enhances the overall variability as the chocolate coat emanates subtle sweetness.



AMUSE BOUCHE I

Mushroom, Foie Gras, and Chinese Mustard



AMUSE BOUCHE II

Egg, Horseradish, Eel

The Second part of amuse bouches is a classical egg amuse, one of the most classical dishes at Taian Table that has been on the menu for a long time. Here the scrambled egg is kissed by the eel that sublimated the simple egg with its tangy ocean umami. The duo is then crowned by a cloud of horseradish that offers subtle spiciness and freshness, counterpointing not only the creaminess but also the texture of both the egg and the eel.



MARINATED BABY HEIRLOOM TOMATOES

Burrata Cheese, Basil

The first appetizer evokes my tasting buds with an innovative version of such a traditional and all-time classical pairing of tomato and mozzarella. Here in this dish, three varieties of tomatoes are executed in three different ways, one of which is marinated in pineapple juice then dehydrated, the other one in raspberry juice then dehydrated, and the last one in yuzu-lime vinaigrette. Four kinds of acidity are displayed in a few bites, including the clean, bitter, and light bodied yuzu citrus, the darker and sweeter raspberry acidity, the tropical pineapple tartness, and the sunny orchard tomato sourness. Burrata, in a similar yet altered way, nourished the trio with its milky aroma and creamy texture, as well as its elegant cheesy acidity.



ARTICHOKE

Foie Gras Terrine, Vinaigrette

Another homage to tradition is this artichoke and foie gras dish rooting in classical Lyonnaise cuisine. Here the foie gras is nesting in a bowl of artichoke and capped with creamy artichoke purée mayonnaise that embraces the foie core with artichoke in two textures. Brioche croutons, parsley, and black truffle are further engulfed in the mayonnaise, adding dimensions of textures and intensive aromas to the yet light artichoke and foie gras.

The foie shows little brininess and is thus countered by a rich and heavy vinaigrette of braised pig trotter, confit tomatoes, chervil, and egg mimosa.



SEA URCHIN

Sourdough Bread, Brown Butter

A compliment is presented to me as a surprise from the chef. The sandwich of Granny Smith, Japanese uni, and sourdough is one of the most famous dishes served at Taian Table. Despite its reputation, I'm regretted to say that this dish could rather be a disappointment.

Uni and bread is another common combination that has been attempted by numerous chefs including César Ramirez of Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare. This dish requires uni to be extremely fresh, creamy, sweet, and rich of umami, nevertheless, Taian Table uses uni that lack of sweetness and creaminess, the addition of green apple reduced the creaminess even more and added unnecessary crispy texture and sourness to the dish. The sourdough per se is too thick and condensed that in a way limited the umami of the already weak uni. The brown butter in the bread further overwhelms the uni with its rich unctuousness.

As the pairing for the first three appetizers, a glass of Egon Müller scharzhof riesling 2018 is offered. Despite of its young age, the wine is easy to drink. From Mosel, this riesling has a lighter and slimmer texture, it's crispy and fresh, dispersing aromas of chamomile, lemon, citrus, and a hint of minerality.



EGON MÜLLER
2018 Scharzhof Riesling



BRITTANY BLUE LOBSTER
Chanterelles Mushrooms, Fresh Almonds

Following the appetizers are a series of three pescetarian dishes, starting with this Brittany blue lobster course. Fine cuts of lobster tail are nesting on a bed of chanterelles mushrooms, Brussel sprouts fricassee, and fresh almonds, decorated with elderberry blossoms and apple leaf. The lobster is barely touched in order to preserve its pristine flavor, while its head was used to make a glaze that is cook with cognac, providing enormous boldness to the reduction.

Next up is a scallop dish featuring bone marrow jus and glazed leeks. Here the scallop is kissed by richness and creaminess from bone marrow jus, the heavy proportion provides essential salinity and unctuousness that brings up the umami from scallop, exhibiting a modern interpretation of surf and turf. Glazed leek is then tailored to counter the richness, bringing a final touch of equilibrium to the melange.



SEARED HOKKAIDO SCALLOP
Bone Marrow | Glazed Leeks



WITTMANN
2018 Riesling Kirchspiel GG

The first two pescetarian dish is paired with the Weingut Wittmann 2018 riesling. The grape comes from Kirchspiel, one of the four VDP Grosses Lages sites of Westhofen of Rheinhessen, resulting in a much silkier texture compared to the riesling from Mosel area. In spite of the silky texture, the wine evokes a fresh bouquet of unripened green orchid fruit and white flowers that goes well with the lobster and scallop.

For the next two courses, a rare German Chardonnay is served to pair with. The chardonnay produced by Weingut Franz Keller comes from Kirchberg, the smallest VDP Grosses Lages sites of Oberrotweil of Baden. This Chardonnay reveals a silky texture, high acidity, light body, and fresh spicy aromas of linden blossom, anise, corn, and other woody notes. Such clear body and high acidity made this wine easy drinking and perfect for complementing the creaminess of the two courses, especially for the beef cheek.



FRANZ KELLER
2016 Oberrotweiler Kirchberg Chardonnay



DOVER SOLE

Porcini Mushrooms | Beluga Lentils

The finale of the pescetarian trio is a dish featuring the precious Dover sole, coated by a thin layer of porcini mushroom scales. The Dover sole is barely touched so that its pristine flavor could be maintained. A layer of porcini mushrooms further sublimated the tasting sensations by providing another dimension of umami. Next to them is deeper cooked porcini mushrooms and beluga lentils, adding interesting contrasts to both textures and flavors.

Following up is the first meat course of the day, chef Stefan Stiller's signature Rheinischer Sauerbraten, featuring beef cheek that has been moderately braised with sous vide for 36 hours. Bitter cacao is blended into the sauce to enrich the flavor with surprise. The sweet raisin is then tailored to balance the bitterness. The dish is finished with fresh chanterelle mushrooms and creamy cauliflowers.



RHEINISCHER SAUERBRATEN

"Slow braised Beef Cheek"
Chanterelle Mushrooms | Cauliflower



WATERMELON SORBET

Pickled Watermelon Skin | Mint

Before the final main course, a palate cleanser is served. The intermission course features a watermelon sorbet and its own pickled skin. The dish is then finished with liquid nitrogen poached mint and dill, operated by a sous chef at the table. The watermelon alone provides essential freshness but the flavor gets weird when it is underscored by dill and mint which lose certain weight of freshness but rather turned bitter and showed abrupt salinity.



PIGEON BREAST

Roasted Pigeon Dashi | Okinawa Spinach | Baby Potato

The centerpiece of the dinner experience is rather a light bodied pigeon dish in which the aged pigeon breast is poached and cooked on the bone to perfection, paired with Okinawa spinach and confit baby potatoes, finished with the pigeon dashi broth that is infused with kombu. Such a combination emanates strong Japanese cuisine spirit, the flavor of all the ingredients is ultimately pristine and pastore, the main umami is sourcing from the dashi, which is pretty similar to kombucha.



PIGEON BREAST

Toast with Duck Liver and Pigeon Liver Cream

The pigeon dish is also paired with a piece of sourdough with liver cream made with both duck and pigeon liver. The liver is lightly overcooked, resulting in a rather harsh texture, nonetheless, the cream evokes strong pigeon umami that pairs perfectly with the dashi even better than the pigeon breast per se.

The wine paired for pigeon is another niche grape variety in German area — Spätburgunder, also known as pinot noir. The pinot noir is from Ölberg, one of the two VDP Grosses Lages sites of Königsbach. The pinot noir carries a hint of licorice and black currant aroma, as well as fragrances of lemon zest, sour cherry, and mint. The aftertaste is rather short.



BASSERMANN-JORDAN

Königsbacher Ölberg Spätburgunder GG



“UMEBOSHI” CREAM CHEESE

Matcha | Dried Strawberries

Moving on to the dessert courses, I’m first served with a quasi cheese course, showcasing cream cheese infused with pickled plum in two different textures, finished with dried strawberries and matcha powder. The cream cheese chips are extremely airy while a quenelle of cream cheese is hidden behind, providing complementary texture and richer cheese flavor. The dried strawberries reveal more condensed, concentrated, and ripened sweetness to counter the salinity, while matcha powdery, on the other hand, exudes a sophisticated freshness that well balanced the creaminess of cream cheese.



CHATEAU CANTEGRIL
2014 Sauternes Denis Dubourdieu

In order to better enhance the flavor of the cream cheese course, a glass of 2014 sauternes is offered complementarily.

The noble sweetness emanates prestige aromas of honey, dehydrated apricot, saffron, elderberry blossom, hibiscus. The wine carries a moderate acidity and a silky buttery texture, well balanced, perfect for pairing the cream cheese.

For the final wine pairing, we return to Riesling from Mosel.

This Riesling produced by Willi Schaefer is an Auslese Riesling, and the grape is sourcing from Domprobst, one of the three VDP Grosses Lages cites of Graacher. Compare to the sauternes wine, the sweetness here is more crystal and cleaner, lighter bodied and fresher. The wine wafts from the glass with neroli blossom and jasmine fragrance.



WILLI SCHAEFER
2018 Graacher Domprobst Riesling Auslese



BLACK CURRANT
Tonka Bean | Black Berries

The final dessert course is rather a simple chocolate dessert paired with black berries, a classical combination easy to find at any place. In spite of the accurate flavor and perfect texture, the overall flavor is not surprising at all.



FAREWELL SWEETS

The first piece of petit fours is a yellow apricot ice cream. Following up is an array of mango tart, passion fruit bourbon, raspberry chocolate, classical Canelé, and coca cola candy. The mango tart renders a similar texture with the apricot ice cream, and the raspberry chocolate echoes the final dessert course. The passionfruit carries a similar tropical fruity aroma with the mango tart, while the canelé brings back the traditional egg cake flavor, the only flaw is that the canelé is way over dehydrated. After having the canelé, the final touch of coca cola candy then brings me back to the modern environment.